Commencing

By Jane Shepard

(A knock on the door. KELLI hurries out, putting on earrings. She checks her watch, her look, grabs jacket, answers door. SHE stops. A WOMAN in a parka stands holding an elaborate bouquet.)

KELLI: **(Pg 37-42)** Oh . . . I was expecting someone else . . . Flowers! Oh God, I'm such a gleeb, come on in! [from] Arlin, right? Let me get my wallet. *(KELLI returns with her purse.)* Those are magnificent!

ARLIN: Hothouse Lilies.

KELLI: Wow, expensive! *(Taking flowers.)* This is a ***very*** *good* start! *(Hands her bills.)* I haven't had a date in six months, and tonight, not only have I lost ten pounds and fit in this dress again but, because of a friend at the office, I have a blind date with a guy who sends me very expensive flowers! Take this ten *and* this twenty, and when you get off work take somebody out and buy them some really expensive flowers! *(KELLI sees ARLIN to the door.)*

ARLIN: I already did. I bought those exact flowers.

KELLI: Well, good choice, worked for me!

ARLIN: Um . . . Your date . . .

KELLI: Wait a minute. He's not coming is he? So these are because -- Oh no, no no no! I am *so* gonna kill Maria tomorrow! She and her friends, who had this guy who would be so 'perfect' for me . . . *(Pushes flowers at ARLIN.)* I'm sorry, just take these back to their point of origin and give them to an orphanage or something. God, I give up, Really, I give up! *(ARLIN is still standing there.)* Show's over, you can go now.

ARLIN: A lot of this is because I have a hard time speaking up. I gave you the wrong impression. *(THEY stare at each other. KELLI finally gets it.)*

KELLI: No. You're Arlin? *(ARLIN nods.)* The *date* Arlin? . . . So now no guy is showing up, and at least one person in the office thinks I'm a lesbian!

ARLIN: Oh, how horrible.

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KELLI: No offense, but I'm not a lesbian.

ARLIN: No offense, but I am. *(Arlin turns to leave)*

KELLI: Wait. Wait a minute, I'm sorry. Um, look, obviously this is very awkward for us both. You should, you should. . . another time maybe -- I mean no, um, bye! *(KELLI closes door on ARLIN and cringes.)* Oooh my Goood! *(Picks up phone & dials.)* Lees, hi it's me, *worst* date night of all time! Blind date, from the office, comes to the door, it's a *woman!!* Somebody set me up with a *woman,* can you believe it! *(Screams)* AAAAA! *(A KNOCK on the door, SHE freezes. Whispering)* Someone's at the door. Could be the lesbian, gotta go, call me!

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Gay, Bi-sexual, Transgendered*
ACTRESS 2: *Some people would like you to believe that if you belong in one of these categories, you are too different from the rest of us to be accepted. You require some very important restrictions:*
ACTRESS 1: *You shouldn't be able to join the military*
ACTRESS 2: *You shouldn't be able to get married*
ACTRESS 1: *You shouldn't be able to adopt a child*
ACTRESS 2: *You just shouldn't . . . be*
ACTRESS 1: *But what if it were possible to focus on our similarities rather than our differences?*
ACTRESS 2: *What if it were possible to see each person for who they truly are rather than seeing only a label?*
TOGETHER: *Commencing by Jane Shepard*

KELLI: **(Pg 42 – 52)** *(Another knock, louder. KELLI answers it.)* Hi -- *(ARLIN bursts in, throwing flowers at KELLI.)*

ARLIN: Here! Those are yours! I bought them for you, and even if you don't want them you can at least have the good grace to pretend until I'm out of sight *(ARLIN stomps OUT. SHE stomps back IN.)* And I don't know who you are that you should be so narrow minded about *who* your date turns out to be! What if I'd been a handsome guy who just wasn't that bright, or a really handsome guy who showed up in a wheelchair? *(pause)* It's just a shame . . . we could have laughed about this and gone to dinner anyway -- you do go to dinner with friends don't you? But no -- *(ARLIN turns to exit.)*

KELLI: Hey! I'm not the bad guy here! Why didn't you just say something!

ARLIN: I was trying!

KELLI: You're a woman, in a big parka, which of those is supposed to tell me you're my date?

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ARLIN: This is my coat, what do you wear? I suppose you have some incredibly cute little "date coat."

KELLI: Don't make fun of me! Why didn't you just say you were the date?

ARLIN: I was a little taken aback, okay? I'm not accustomed to being handed a tip in the first ten seconds that I meet someone.

KELLI: Oh . . . *(sheepishly)* and I do have a date coat. *(Holds up little jacket.)* It's not real warm. I'm always cold on dates.

ARLIN: I think one of the most asinine things you can do is go out to have fun, and purposely wear something that makes you uncomfortable. Not so much you personally, but straight women in general -- you wear those little tight clothes & the little pointy shoes. I mean, if you're gonna go out & hang loose & live large . . . it wouldn't hurt you to get a decent pair of shoes with some support. Don't teeter around in those little pin-pricks. *(Pause. KELLI looks at her.)*

KELLI: Men love it when you teeter.

ARLIN: Oh, they sure do. It's just so sexy when a woman is struggling at all times just to keep her balance. That is so sexy.

KELLI: *(Spinning to show off her outfit)* If you were a man you wouldn't want to take me out?

ARLIN: I'm a woman and I wanted to take you out!

KELLI: So you get the point!

ARLIN: Why do straight women like to do that? There's a little part of you that just can't resist trying to see if we find you attractive. Just to see.

KELLI: And why are ***you*** allowed to make these generalizations?! How come if I say, "You lesbians love coming on to straight women," it sounds like a horrible ignorant stereotype! But if *you* say, "Straight women love coming on to gays," it comes off like some hip, witty little insight! Why are you allowed to get away with that?

ARLIN: Gee I dunnow, maybe it's compensation for the last couple centuries. It hasn't been that long since ***it*** was still legally a mental illness. And they could do anything, have you committed, perform lobotomies, sterilize you, whatever! Ancient history, right? Except right now in Connecticut there's a case pending of a woman trying to regain custody of her son, which she lost simply for being a lesbian!

KELLI: Earth to person, lighten up! Take a pill or something. And you better either leave or take off that parka 'cause you're so red you look like you're gonna explode. You want some water or something? *(ARLIN nods yes and takes her coat off. KELLI gets the water.)*

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ARLIN: I'm not gonna stay or anything.

KELLI: Well good, because I don't think we're going to come to a deeper understanding through love and laughter. *(Hands Arlin the water, which she drinks)*

ARLIN: Thanks *(Awkward pause.)* I should be taking off pretty quick.

KELLI: Don't get all shy on me now, dudette, you've thrown stuff at me and had a tizzy in my living room. Don't get all weird now just 'cause you took off your parka.

ARLIN: Doesn't this feel sort of date-like all of a sudden? Y'know, those awkward moments at the start of dates.

KELLI: Yeah, especially blind dates. What's your name again? Harley?

ARLIN: Arlin. Why?

KELLI: It's just funny, because Arlin could be a man or a woman's name, and you're . . .

ARLIN: A man or a woman? . . . **(Pg 61)** Do you have any pretzels?

KELLI: I thought you weren't staying.

ARLIN: I'm not, I just thought we'd be at dinner by now and I haven't eaten.

KELLI: I have Fritos.

ARLIN: Thank you. *(KELLI gets them.)* I'm not staying, I just need something to bring my blood sugar up. *(Puts a handful of Fritos in her mouth)*

KELLI: **(Pg 64)** Can I ask you something? *(a skeptical look from Arlin)* C'mon, you're eating my Fritos

ARLIN: So not worth it!

KELLI: **(Pg 52-53)** I'm gonna have a **real** drink now, do you mind?

ARLIN: No.

KELLI: Oh good. Because some people, if they're officially "non-drinkers", they can't handle it if you wanna have any fun . . . Are you officially a non-drinker?

ARLIN: Mm-hm.

KELLI: Are you alcoholic?

ARLIN: Yes.

KELLI: Man. I'm sorry, I can't believe I just asked you that. Really, I apologize, I just, for some reason, things come blurting out of my mouth with you that I would never normally say. It's really weird. Anyway, I'm sorry.

ARLIN: . . . Are you afraid you drink too much? Is that why you're asking?

KELLI: **(Pg 54-56)** Well, my blind date blew apart and I'm spending the evening with a perfectly nice

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alcoholic lesbian, I think that rates . . . Johnnie Walker. *(Silence. SHE looks at ARLIN.)* I meant that jovially . . . *(ARLIN doesn't reply.) (Kelly downs the shot of Johnnie Walker)* I'm sorry. Don't mind what I say. *(ARLIN puts down her drink and gets her parka.)* What? Oh come on, don't do that, I didn't mean anything. Don't go away angry -- what's your name? *(SHE goes to get herself another drink . . . and downs that as well)*

ARLIN: Arlin!

KELLI: Look. The thing is, I just don't know whether you're coming on to me or not. And I just have no idea how to respond, you know, because I don't know what's what. God, don't be mad. I'm just being honest.

ARLIN: Well trust me, I'm not putting the moves on you. *(Kelli gets herself another drink . . and downs that as well)*

KELLI: **(Pg 58)** I'm not an alcoholic, Arlin. It's not a problem for me, okay? *(starting to slur her words a bit – looks Arlin up and down)* **(Pg 66-78)** Suffice it to say, I am not attracting quite the same dating scene I did before.

ARLIN: Before what?

KELLI: Before they redrew the map. The everything map. Before you have any idea that this kind of thing can happen. Before that time, you live in, whatsit, ignorant bliss! Before the *mail* comes in, Arlin. Before the mail comes in. *That's* where I went wrong! If anybody ever leaves you, *don't open the mail!* It was 'Before', before I opened the mail! After that, it was nothing but 'After.'

ARLIN: You know, I think Mr. Johnnie Walker is beginning to --

KELLI: Once you open the mail, you can never go back to ignorant bliss. Once you see the statement, you can never go back and *not* know what it looks like when someone has maxed out your credit cards. And you never want to know that your bank accounts can read sudden zero. *(Kelli gets herself another drink . . and downs that as well)* Keep your finances separate, Arlin, that's all I can say. If you're gonna get married, don't combine.

ARLIN: Not likely to be a problem.

KELLI: Keep everything separate! Bank accounts, charge cards, loans, -- even if it's more costly. Don't get married, because it completely changes the definition of the phrase "getting screwed"!

ARLIN: I'm sorry. I see you're still very, very hurt. *(Long pause)* They say in A. A. not to bother bandying words with a drunk, because only one of you will remember it in the morning.

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KELLI: *(Aggressively and bitterly)* That me? The drunk? *(Kelli, jabs her finger against Arlin's check to emphasize key words)* The sheen coming off your A. A. tiara is giving me a migraine. *(Frustrated, ARLIN hurls her water glass against a wall, it shatters, her head jerks back, struck by flying glass. KELLI sees that ARLIN is injured and sobers immediately)* Are you hurt? Lemme see.

ARLIN: A piece of glass ricocheted. Did I get blood on your floor?

KELLI: *(looks at the shattered glass)* A little with the glass, it'll come up.

ARLIN: *(stops Kelli with a hand on her arm, scared)* Lemme do it.

KELLI: Don't worry about it, go wash your face.

ARLIN: You should use rubber gloves. If that's my blood, you should use rubber gloves.

KELLI: Well why, it's not like you have . . .

(KELLI stops. ARLIN watches her response warily. It hits KELLI hard, this reality. That Arlin's blood is not safe. What that means. THEY stand staring at one another, emotions running beneath frozen exteriors. Finally ARLIN moves.)

ARLIN: As a precaution. Use some gloves.

KELLI: *(Softly)* Okay.

(ARLIN goes OFF into bathroom. KELLI goes OFF into kitchen, comes back wearing rubber gloves, cleans up, still stunned.) (ARLIN emerges with a Band-Aid, putting it on her own face.)

KELLI: You missed. *(KELLI points to Arlin's Band-Aid. ARLIN adjusts the Band-Aid on her cheek.)*

ARLIN: Okay?

KELLI: Not quite. *(Hesitantly, KELLI reaches up and tries to fix it, but it's tricky with rubber gloves on.)* It's uh . . . Here. *(KELLI pulls her gloves off and adjusts the bandage.)* Now, this is not a come-on.

(SHE sits beside ARLIN, puts the Band-Aid on her, sticking its edges to Arlin's face carefully, tenderly. SHE traces the outline of the Band-Aid, touches Arlin's face. ARLIN closes her eyes. KELLI holds Arlin's face in her hand. Not so much sexually as intimately, with the knowledge of Arlin's mortality hanging over them, and loneliness hovering around them, and all that has passed between them. A long moment. THEY break apart simultaneously.)

KELLI: Well . . .

ARLIN: *(softly)* Hey c'mon, don't get all shy on me now, dudette. You've shouted at me & thrown me out, don't get all weird now just because I bled in your house.

KELLI: *(near tears)* It makes me sad. It really makes me sad, Arlin. *(pause)* I'm sorry.

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ARLIN: *(humor abandoned, Arlin speaks honestly and frankly)* Because I have HIV? I get scared sometimes. And I'm lonely a lot of the time. But mostly, I wouldn't trade it, Kelli. Not even to have all my health back, I wouldn't, I wouldn't go back where you are now. *(long pause then she begins again)* On the wall at the planetarium it says, "A **man** can reach the stars if **he** can dream of it!" What about women? And they say, "Oh, well, by Man we mean everyone, all Mankind!" I don't think of [myself] as Mankind, I just feel left out. But hey, when you run the language, you call the shots. Who decided we were Mankind? It's not our story, it's history! It's all male-oriented. And it *sounds* like small stuff, but it's subtle. [It's] like HIV. Once it's in the blood, it effects everything . . . *(thoughtfully)* Except one word. I know one female-rooted word!

KELLI: What?

ARLIN: Commence. Co-mensing, as in menstruation? Meaning to flow forward together. Isn't that nice? Let us commence.

KELLI: ***Nice?!*** Something in your [world] is actually nice?

ARLIN: *(Wryly)* Yeah. One thing. *(shrugs her shoulders)* It's a start. Let us commence. [After all] my date was a bust.

KELLI: *(smiling)* No it wasn't. It wasn't even a date.

ARLIN: No? What was it?

KELLI: It was . . . . *(holds out hand to Arlin, who takes it in her own)* a commencement! *(they smile at one another)*

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